$\vec{E}_1$ is a vector quantity that points towards the mass m_1 and is independent of mass m_2, Here m_2 is taken to be of unit magnitude . The unit $\hat{r}$ is along the line between m_1 and the point in question. The field $\vec{E}_1$ is due to the mass m_1.

In general, the gravitational field intensity due to a mass M at a distance r is given by

$$\vec{E} = -\frac{GM}{r^2}\hat{r} \qquad (6.16)$$

Now in the region of this gravitational field, a mass 'm' is placed at a point P (Figure 6.9). Mass 'm' interacts with the field $\vec{E}$ and experiences an attractive force due to M as shown in Figure 6.9. The gravitational force experienced by 'm' due to 'M' is given by

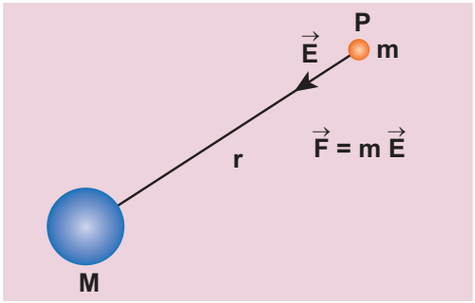


Figure 6.9 Gravitational Field intensity measured with an object of unit mass

$$\vec{F}_m = m\vec{E} \qquad (6.17)$$

Now we can equate this with Newton's second law $\vec{F} = m\vec{a}$

$$m\vec{a} = m\vec{E} \qquad (6.18)$$

$$\vec{a} = \vec{E} \qquad (6.19)$$

In other words, equation (6.18) implies that the gravitational field at a point is equivalent to the acceleration experienced by a particle at that point. However, it is to be noted that $\vec{a}$ and $\vec{E}$ are separate physical quantities that have the same magnitude and direction. The gravitational field $\vec{E}$ is the property of the source and acceleration $\vec{a}$ is the effect experienced by the test mass (unit mass) which is placed in the gravitational field $\vec{E}$. The non-contact interaction between two masses can now be explained using the concept of "Gravitational field".

Points to be noted:

i) The strength of the gravitational field decreases as we move away from the mass M as depicted in the Figure 6.10. The magnitude of $\vec{E}$ decreases as the distance r increases.

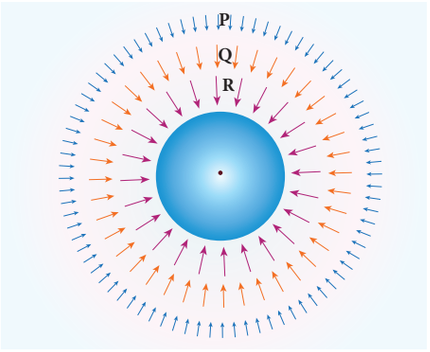


Figure 6.10 Strength of the Gravitational field lines decreases with distance

Figure 6.10 shows that the strength of the gravitational field at points P, Q, and R is given by $|\vec{E}_P| < |\vec{E}_Q| < |\vec{E}_R|$. It can be understood by comparing the length of the vectors at points P, Q, and R.

ii) The "field" concept was introduced as a mathematical tool to calculate gravitational interaction. Later it was found that field is a real physical quantity and it carries energy and momentum in

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